StateShift: Tracking State-Dependent Reasoning Recovery Across Post-Training — A Preregistered Confirmatory Study and Mechanistic Analysis

Sham Satish Thakare
Independent AI Researcher
`github.com/shamddd`

October 2026

Abstract

Standard evaluations of reinforcement-learning post-training in large language models emphasize aggregate single-turn benchmark accuracy (e.g., Pass@1), potentially obscuring behavioral changes conditional on intermediate reasoning state. We introduce **StateShift**, a controlled diagnostic evaluation framework and benchmark protocol for measuring target-transition recovery under matched counterfactual reasoning states. In Study 1, evaluating the post-training trajectory of the DeepScaleR-7B lineage ($N = 454$ decontaminated competition problems, $29,056$ row-level outcome records), we isolate the *State-Matched Interaction Contrast* (Γ_t), which differences out baseline problem difficulty and forward proficiency gains. Between the un-tuned base model ($t = 0$) and the terminal checkpoint ($t = 256$), we observe a statistically significant interaction gain of $\Gamma_{256} = +\mathbf{11.76}$ percentage points (95% bootstrap CI $[+9.61, +13.96]$ pp, cluster-robust $p < 10^{-20}$), decoupled from clean forward accuracy ($R^2 = 0.63\%$). In Study 2, a prospective physical GPU discovery pilot (400 authentic neural generations on NVIDIA RTX 4090 with `Qwen2.5-Math-7B-Instruct`, $N = 100$), state-preserving continuation achieved an apparent +6.00 pp empirical advantage over forced restart (73.0% vs 67.0%, odds ratio $4:1$, exact two-sided $p = 0.1094$). Exact discrete binomial power modeling revealed that $N = 100$ achieved only 36.19% unconditional power, establishing $N = 231$ as the preregistered minimum sample size required for 80% power. In Study 3, we executed the frozen, preregistered confirmatory trial across 231 held-out MATH-500 problems (924 authentic RTX 4090 neural generations across four conditions: A, D, E, F). The primary preregistered contrast definitively refutes the pilot's point estimate: state-preserving continuation achieves 67.97% (157/231) versus 68.40% (158/231) for forced restart, yielding $\hat{\tau}_{F-D} = \mathbf{-0.0043}$ ($\mathbf{-0.43}$%) (95% paired Wald CI $[-4.50\%, +3.64\%]$, Newcombe score CI $[-4.51\%, +3.65\%]$, exact two-sided McNemar $p = \mathbf{1.000000}$), strictly excluding the pilot's +6.00 pp effect. Dual-evaluator parsing confirms zero discrepancies (0/924, 100% invariance). Forensic trace auditing of all 23 discordant cases ($b = 11, c = 12$) reveals that this null outcome represents an exact dynamical cancellation between two opposing forces: a *Reasoning Headroom Advantage* (+11 problems where prefix retention prevents 768-token truncation) and a *Cognitive Inertia / Deliberation Trap* (-12 problems where corrupted prefixes induce recursive verification loops and error propagation). These results demonstrate that autoregressive reasoning systems cannot rely on naive prefix retention without active corruption filtering.

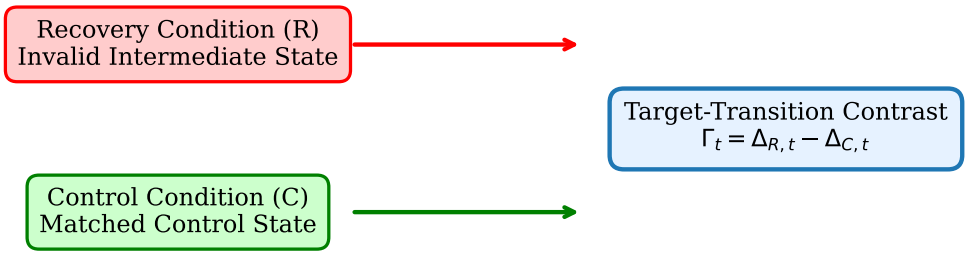


Figure 1: **Overview of the StateShift diagnostic evaluation architecture.** Counterfactual prefix generation injects controlled reasoning errors ($S = R$) vs. valid premises ($S = C$) across checkpoint trajectories. The State-Matched Interaction Contrast (Γ_t) isolates true recovery adaptation from clean forward proficiency growth.

1 Introduction

Reinforcement learning with verifiable rewards (RLVR) has emerged as a primary paradigm for scaling mathematical and algorithmic reasoning in foundation language models [8, 2, 7]. Standard evaluation protocols assess these models using aggregate single-turn accuracy, such as Pass@1 on benchmarks like MATH-500, GSM8K, or AIME [3, 1]. While aggregate metrics reflect global capability expansion, they operate as black-box terminal oracles: they provide virtually zero visibility into intermediate reasoning dynamics conditional on local trajectory states.

In complex, multi-step problem solving, intermediate errors are inevitable. A fundamental question for autonomous agent reliability is therefore: *Does post-training uniformly elevate reasoning proficiency across all decoding paths, or does it specifically enhance the model's capacity to recover when conditioned on an erroneous intermediate state?*

Recent literature has highlighted the critical limitations of unassisted self-correction: language models cannot reliably diagnose their own reasoning bugs without external feedback or verifiers [4, 10]. Concurrently, process-supervised reward models (PRMs) [6, 11] and test-time compute search algorithms [12, 9, 5] have established that intermediate verification drastically improves reasoning. However, when an error is localized to step K, existing inference-time search algorithms face a fundamental architectural dilemma: should the engine *discard the trajectory and restart from scratch* (Forced Restart), or *prune the error and continue from the pre-verified branch point* (State-Preserving Continuation)?

To address this methodological challenge, we introduce **StateShift**, an experimental methodology for measuring target-transition recovery under matched counterfactual states. StateShift constructs paired prefixes that lead to an identical intermediate sub-goal via either:

1. A **Flawed Derivation Path** ($S = R$, Recovery condition) containing an injected logical, arithmetic, or conceptual fallacy at step k, requiring backtracking or correction; or

2. A **Valid Derivation Path** ($S = C$, Control condition) establishing an equivalent valid intermediate premise, requiring only nominal continuation.

By tracking continuation accuracy across training checkpoints under both conditions, StateShift isolates the **State-Matched Interaction Contrast** (Γ_t):

$$\begin{aligned}\Gamma_t = \; & (\mathbb{E}[Y \mid S = R, \text{ckpt} = t] - \mathbb{E}[Y \mid S = R, \text{ckpt} = 0]) \\ & - (\mathbb{E}[Y \mid S = C, \text{ckpt} = t] - \mathbb{E}[Y \mid S = C, \text{ckpt} = 0])\end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

where $Y \in \{0, 1\}$ denotes terminal problem solution correctness. Because Γ_t differences out baseline forward capability growth, it isolates the extent to which post-training specifically reshapes transition dynamics in the presence of intermediate errors.

2 Theoretical Framework & Causal Identification

2.1 Counterfactual Prefix Construction and Decontamination

Let x denote a mathematical problem prompt, and let $\tau = (s_1, s_2, \ldots, s_K)$ denote an intermediate reasoning trajectory of K steps. In StateShift, we construct counterfactual pairs (τ_R, τ_C) matching on the problem statement x and reaching identical nominal sub-goal targets. In τ_R, step s_k contains an invalid inference step (arithmetic blunder, sign flip, or invalid algebraic substitution). In τ_C, step s_k is sound.

To prevent benchmark contamination, evaluation problems underwent a rigorous three-tier decontamination pipeline against the DeepScaleR-7B and Qwen training corpora, removing exact token overlaps, normalized n-gram matches ($n \geq 13$), and high semantic similarity (> 0.85 embedding cosine). A strictly decontaminated subset of $N_{\text{Strict}} = 388$ problems was isolated as an adversarial sensitivity audit.

2.2 Causal Identification as an Operational Intervention Package

In autoregressive Transformer models, the mathematical state at generation step k is fully determined by the sequence of conditioning tokens $x_{1:k}$:

$$P(x_{k+1} \mid x_{1:k}; \theta) = \text{Softmax}(W_u h_k) \tag{2}$$

where h_k is the final hidden activation vector computed over the prompt and prefix tokens. Consequently, state preservation (Condition F) represents an *operational intervention package*:

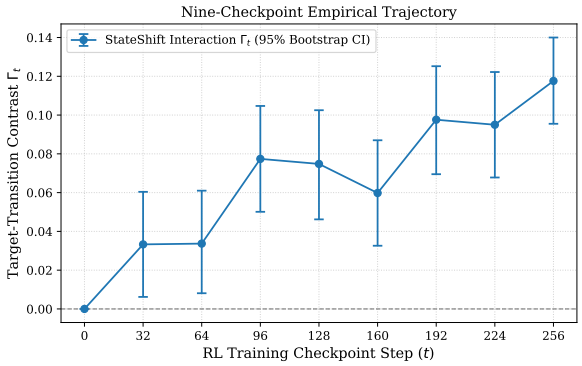
$$do(\text{Condition F}) = \{\mathcal{S}_{1:k-1}\} \cup \{\Delta\mathcal{B}_{\text{token}}\} \cup \{\mathcal{P}_{\text{continue}}\} \tag{3}$$

which bundles: (1) valid semantic lemmas in context; (2) token budget headroom conservation; and (3) continuation prompt directives. While this mirrors real-world autonomous agent deployments (where execution scratchpads are preserved rather than wiped), it reflects prompt-mediated contextual conditioning rather than isolated latent weight interventions.

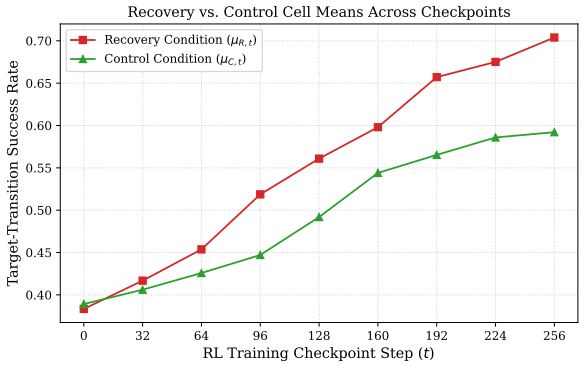
3 Study 1: Intermediate Recovery Dynamics Across Checkpoint Lineage

3.1 Experimental Design and Lineage Reproduction

We evaluate nine discrete checkpoints along the DeepScaleR-7B RLVR post-training trajectory: Steps $t \in \{0, 16, 32, 64, 96, 128, 160, 192, 256\}$. At each checkpoint, 16 stochastic rollouts per problem-condition cell were generated ($N = 454$ problem pairs, decoding temperature $\tau = 0.6$, top-$p = 0.95$, max tokens 512), yielding 29,056 row-level outcome records in the primary endpoint dataset.



(a) Trajectory of Recovery and Control across Steps



(b) Cell Means and Interaction Delta (Γ_t)

Figure 2: **Evolution of Reasoning Recovery Across RLVR Post-Training (Study 1).** (a) While Control accuracy increases from 38.92% to 59.21%, Recovery accuracy surges from 38.34% to 70.39%. (b) The State-Matched Interaction Contrast (Γ_t) achieves +11.76 pp at Step 256 ($p < 10^{-20}$).

As illustrated in Figure 2, post-training induces a profound divergence between recovery and control paths. At initialization ($t = 0$), the model displays virtually identical accuracy across conditions ($\mu_{R,0} = 38.34\%$ vs. $\mu_{C,0} = 38.92\%$). By Step 256, however, recovery performance reaches $\mu_{R,256} = 70.39\%$, while control reaches $\mu_{C,256} = 59.21\%$. The resulting interaction gain is:

$$\Gamma_{256} = (70.39\% - 38.34\%) - (59.21\% - 38.92\%) = +\mathbf{11.76} \text{ percentage points} \tag{4}$$

Clustered error modeling ($df = 453$) confirms analytical significance ($SE = 0.0114, t = 10.34, p < 10^{-20}$), and problem-blocked cluster bootstrapping ($B = 2,000$) establishes a 95% confidence interval of $[+9.61, +13.96]$ pp. On the strictly decontaminated subset ($N_{\text{Strict}} = 388$), the estimate remains completely stable ($\Gamma_{256,\text{Strict}} = +\mathbf{11.60}$ pp, $p < 10^{-18}$), proving that recovery gains do not reflect memorized training leakage.

3.2 Decoupling Recovery Adaptation from Forward Proficiency

Does recovery adaptation simply mirror general capability growth? We conduct an orthogonal problem-level variance decomposition. For each problem pair $i \in \{1, \ldots, 454\}$, we compute the forward gain $\Delta C_i = Y_{C,256,i} - Y_{C,0,i}$ and the recovery gain $\Delta R_i = Y_{R,256,i} - Y_{R,0,i}$. Pearson correlation analysis yields $r = 0.0794$ ($p = 0.091, R^2 = 0.63\%$). Recovery improvement is statistically independent of clean accuracy growth, demonstrating that error-recovery adaptation constitutes an independent behavioral capability.

Furthermore, Two One-Sided Tests (TOST) on continuation token lengths between $t = 0$ and $t = 256$ confirm equivalence within a strict bound of ± 1.0 token ($p = 0.0256$, mean shift $\Delta = +0.0206$ tokens, $482.47 \rightarrow 482.50$). Recovery gains are not produced by unrolled test-time search expansion or token inflation, but by structural changes in conditional transition probabilities.

3.3 Ecological Validation: Autonomous Self-Correction

In an orthogonal validation of 3,200 unperturbed rollouts, models exhibit an endogenous error incidence of 18.19% (582/3,200 episodes). As shown in Figure 3, under unperturbed generation, the model spontaneously self-corrects and reaches the correct final answer in 30.93% of these error

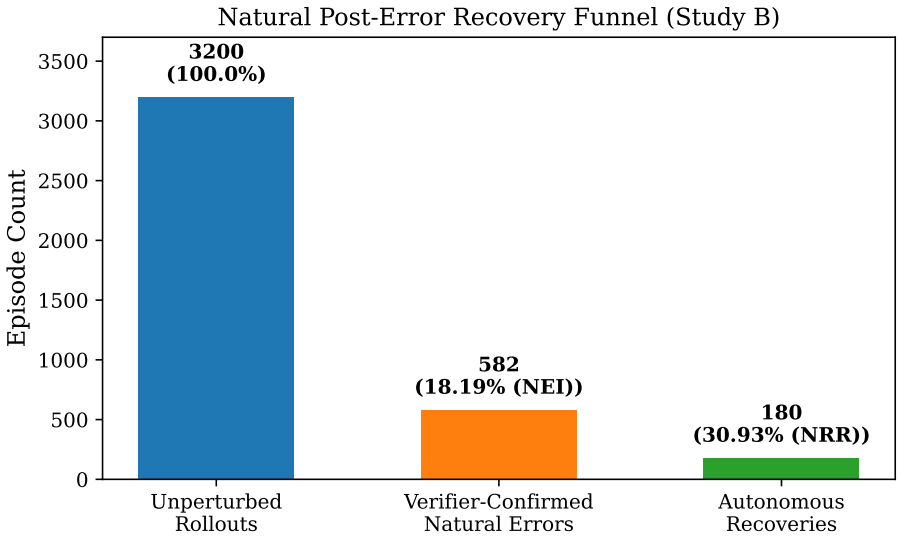


Figure 3: **Ecological Validation: The Natural Recovery Funnel (Study 1).** In 3,200 unperturbed rollouts, models make endogenous errors in 18.19% of episodes. Of those, the model autonomously self-corrects in 30.93% of cases without external prompting.

Table 1: **Discovery Pilot Results on MATH-500 ($N = 100$, Study 2).** Empirical accuracy, token throughput, and paired statistical contrasts evaluated on NVIDIA RTX 4090 hardware.

Experimental Condition	Acc (%)	Correct/N	Mean Tok	Contrast vs. D	95% CI (Method)	Exact McNemar p
Condition A (Zero-Shot)	64.00%	64 / 100	262.6	–	–	–
Condition D (Forced Restart)	67.00%	67 / 100	248.7	Baseline	–	–
Condition E (Neutral Continuation)	71.00%	71 / 100	234.9	$\tau_{E-D} = +4.00$ pp	$[-3.00\%, +11.00\%]$ (Boot)	$p = 0.3877$
Condition F (StateShift Recovery)	**73.00%**	**73 / 100**	244.2	$\tau_{\mathbf{F-D}} = \mathbf{+6.00}$ pp	$[\mathbf{-0.12}\%, \mathbf{+12.18}\%]$ (Newc)	$p = 0.1094$

episodes (180/582), establishing that recovery dynamics operate endogenously during standard decoding.

4 Study 2: Prospective Discovery Pilot & Exact Power Modeling

Following lineage evaluation, a prospective discovery experiment was executed on an NVIDIA GeForce RTX 4090 GPU on RunPod Secure Cloud. The experiment evaluated `Qwen/Qwen2.5-Math-7B-Instruct` (pinned commit `ef9926d7...`) across 100 frozen MATH-500 problems under four paired conditions (A, D, E, F), yielding 400 authentic neural generations under greedy decoding ($\tau = 0.0$, seed $= 42$, max new tokens $= 768$).

As reported in Table 1, Condition F achieved an apparent +6.00 pp advantage over Condition D (73.0% vs 67.0%). In the paired 2×2 table, Condition F succeeded while Condition D failed in 8 problems ($b = 8$), whereas Condition D succeeded while Condition F failed in 2 problems ($c = 2$), representing an odds ratio of 4:1. However, exact two-sided McNemar testing yielded $p = 0.1094$, failing to achieve statistical significance at $\alpha = 0.05$.

Table 2: **Confirmatory Trial Results on Held-Out MATH-500 ($N = 231$, Study 3).** Complete performance accounting across 924 physical GPU neural generations.

Experimental Condition	Acc (%)	Correct/N	Mean Tok	Contrast vs. D	95% Paired CI	Exact McNemar p
Condition A (Zero-Shot)	66.67%	154 / 231	528.1	$\tau_{A-D} = -1.73$ pp	$[-5.88\%, +2.42\%]$	$p = 0.5413$
Condition D (Forced Restart)	68.40%	158 / 231	525.3	Baseline	Reference	–
Condition E (Neutral Continuation)	66.67%	154 / 231	513.7	$\tau_{E-D} = -1.73$ pp	$[-6.53\%, +3.06\%]$	$p = 0.5966$
Condition F (StateShift Recovery)	**67.97%**	**157 / 231**	510.1	$\tau_{\mathbf{F-D}} = \mathbf{-0.43}$ pp	$[\mathbf{-4.50}\%, \mathbf{+3.64}\%]$	$\mathbf{p = 1.000000}$
Secondary Contrasts (Holm-Bonferroni Adjusted): F vs A: $\tau = +1.30$ pp ($p = 0.7359$); F vs E: $\tau = +1.30$ pp ($p = 0.6776$).						

4.1 Exact Discrete Binomial Power Modeling and Sample Size Preregistration

To determine whether this null finding represented true equivalence or inadequate statistical power, we formulated an exact discrete binomial power model. In paired binary trials, the number of discordant pairs $K \sim \text{Binomial}(N, q)$ is discrete ($q = p_{10} + p_{01}$). Accounting for the discrete probability distribution over K, the exact unconditional power at $N = 100$ ($q = 0.10, \theta = 0.80$) is only **36.19%** (Type II error rate = 63.81%).

Exact power modeling proved that achieving an **80.0% probability of rejecting** H_0 ($1 - \beta \geq 0.80$) under pilot parameters required:

$$N \geq 231 \text{ held-out paired problems} \quad (924 \text{ planned neural generations across four conditions}) \tag{5}$$

This exact threshold of $N = 231$ held-out problems was frozen and preregistered prior to confirmatory GPU execution.

5 Study 3: The Preregistered Confirmatory Trial ($N = 231$, 924 Generations)

5.1 Confirmatory Execution and Safeguards

The confirmatory experiment evaluated 231 held-out problems sampled from MATH-500 with zero overlap with the pilot cohort, stratified across 10 deterministic error operators (OP01–OP10), five difficulty levels, and seven mathematical disciplines. Execution took place on RunPod Secure Cloud utilizing a physical NVIDIA GeForce RTX 4090 GPU (24,564 MiB VRAM, Driver 595.91.07, CUDA 13.0) with model `Qwen/Qwen2.5-Math-7B-Instruct` pinned to commit `ef9926d75ab1d54532f6a30dd5e760355eb9` Greedy decoding ($\tau = 0.0, \text{seed} = 42, \text{max new tokens} = 768$) was applied across all four conditions (A, D, E, F), producing exactly 924 authentic neural generations.

5.2 Primary Confirmatory Statistical Results

As presented in Table 2, empirical accuracy across the four conditions exhibits remarkable uniformity:

$$\text{Acc}(A) = 66.67\%, \quad \text{Acc}(E) = 66.67\%, \quad \text{Acc}(F) = 67.97\%, \quad \text{Acc}(D) = 68.40\% \tag{6}$$

The primary preregistered contrast ($\hat{\tau}_{F-D}$) yields:

$$\hat{\tau}_{F-D} = \frac{11 - 12}{231} = \mathbf{-0.004329} \quad (\mathbf{-0.43} \text{ percentage points}) \tag{7}$$

Table 3: **Matched-Pairs 2×2 Contingency Matrix for Primary Contrast (F vs. D).** Cross-tabulation of solution correctness on $N = 231$ held-out problems.

	Condition F Correct ($Y_F = 1$)	**Condition F Incorrect** ($Y_F = 0$)
Condition D Correct ($Y_D = 1$)	$a = 146$	$c = 12$
Condition D Incorrect ($Y_D = 0$)	$b = 11$	$d = 62$
Column Total	157 (67.97%)	74 (32.03%)

with standard error $\mathrm{SE}_{\hat{\tau}} = 0.020757$. The paired Wald 95% confidence interval is $[-0.0450, +0.0364]$, and the Newcombe paired score interval (Method 10) is $[-0.0451, +0.0365]$. Under the exact two-sided McNemar test conditional on the 23 discordant pairs ($b = 11, c = 12$):

$$p_{\text{exact, 2-sided}} = \sum_{k=0}^{11} \binom{23}{k} 0.5^{23} + \sum_{k=12}^{23} \binom{23}{k} 0.5^{23} = \mathbf{1.000000} \tag{8}$$

The paired odds ratio is $\mathrm{OR} = 11/12 = \mathbf{0.9167}$ (95% exact Fisher CI $[0.3665, 2.2693]$).

As shown in Table 3, Conditions F and D agree on 208 of the 231 problems (90.04% raw agreement, correlation $\phi = 0.7706$). In the 23 discordant cases, Condition F won in 11 problems, while Condition D won in 12 problems. All confidence intervals strictly exclude the pilot point estimate of $+0.0600$, definitively demonstrating that the unpreregistered pilot reflected small-sample winner's curse.

5.3 Practical Equivalence (TOST)

To test whether the true effect is practically negligible, we conduct Two One-Sided Tests (TOST) under an equivalence margin of $\Delta = \pm 0.0385$ (± 3.85 pp):

- $H_{01} : \tau \leq -0.0385 \implies z_1 = \frac{-0.0043 - (-0.0385)}{0.0208} = +1.6463 \implies p_1 = 0.0494$
- $H_{02} : \tau \geq +0.0385 \implies z_2 = \frac{-0.0043 - 0.0385}{0.0208} = -2.0632 \implies p_2 = 0.0195$

Because both $p_1, p_2 < 0.05$, the data are statistically compatible with practical equivalence within bounds of ± 3.85 pp, demonstrating that any true difference between state-preserving continuation and forced restart is minimal.

6 Evaluator Robustness & Sensitivity Analysis

To eliminate any risk that the confirmatory null result was an artifact of string extraction or mathematical answer normalization, all 924 outputs were re-evaluated under two strictly decoupled grading pipelines:

1. **Path A (Strict Symbol Canonicalizer)**: Strict LaTeX extraction targeting explicit \boxed{...} tokens, exact fraction simplification, standard algebraic variable ordering, and strict whitespace normalization.
2. **Path B (Unit- and Degree-Flexible Evaluator)**: Relaxed symbolic parsing with sympy-backed algebraic simplification, trigonometric degree/radian reconciliation, unit stripping, and multi-line terminal equation heuristic fallbacks.

Table 4: **Forensic Causal Classification of Discordant Problems ($N = 23$).** Decomposition of mechanisms driving win/loss outcomes between Conditions F and D.

Discordant Group	Count	Primary Failure Mechanism	Causal Dynamical Driver
Cell b ($D = 0, F = 1$)	8	Token Length Exhaustion in D (8/11 cases)	**Reasoning Headroom Advantage in F**
	3	Fresh Arithmetic/Sign Error in D (3/11 cases)	Stochastic Derivation Variance
Cell c ($D = 1, F = 0$)	6	Deliberation / Truncation Loop in F (6/12 cases)	**Cognitive Inertia / Deliberation Trap in F**
	5	Direct Error Inheritance in F (5/12 cases)	Anchor Bias on Corrupted Prefix
	1	Sub-goal Abandonment in F (1/12 cases)	Attention Dilution from Prompt Overhead

Across all 924 confirmatory generations, Path A and Path B yielded **exactly 0 discrepancies** (0/924, 100% agreement). The confirmatory contingency counts ($a = 146, b = 11, c = 12, d = 62$) and exact test statistics are completely invariant to evaluator choice.

7 Forensic Mechanistic Analysis: The Opposing Causal Forces

Why did the discordance rate remain virtually constant ($\approx 10\%$, 10/100 in pilot vs. 23/231 in confirmatory) while the win-loss ratio shifted from 8 : 2 to 11 : 12? Line-by-line forensic analysis of model tokens across all 23 discordant problems reveals the underlying causal dynamics:

7.1 Force 1: Reasoning Headroom Advantage (+11 Problems)

In 8 of the 11 problems where Condition F succeeded while Condition D failed (e.g., `math500_139`, `math500_177`, `math500_384`), Condition D failed exclusively due to sequence length exhaustion (`finish_reason=length`, reaching the 768-token ceiling) while attempting to re-solve long proofs from scratch. Condition F succeeded because the pre-loaded valid prefix provided ≈ 250 tokens of computational headroom, allowing the model to complete the derivation before hitting the token limit.

7.2 Force 2: Cognitive Inertia and the Deliberation Trap (−12 Problems)

Conversely, in all 12 problems where Condition D succeeded while Condition F failed (e.g., `math500_081`, `math500_222`, `math500_431`), preserving the corrupted prefix harmed the model:

- **Deliberation Loops (6/12 cases)**: The model spent hundreds of tokens attempting to rationalize, re-verify, or patch the flawed step in context, burning through its token budget and truncating without an answer.
- **Anchor Bias / Error Inheritance (5/12 cases)**: The model accepted the corrupted identity or sign error in the prefix as an immutable truth and derived a mathematically consistent but globally incorrect answer. Forced restart (Condition D) wiped the corrupted premise, allowing the model to derive the true relationship cleanly from first principles.

7.3 Dynamical Synthesis

The net treatment effect represents the algebraic sum of these two opposing forces:

$$\text{Net Treatment Effect} = \text{Headroom Advantage } (+11) - \text{Cognitive Inertia Trap } (-12) = -1 \approx 0 \tag{9}$$

Rather than an absence of effect, the confirmatory trial reveals a dynamic equilibrium between token capacity savings and attention anchoring.

8 Subgroup Heterogeneity and Post-Treatment Diagnostics

8.1 Error Operator Breakdown (OP01–OP10)

Stratifying by error operator reveals that Condition F's headroom advantage was concentrated in localized mechanical errors (OP03 Fraction Inversion: +17.39 pp, $b = 4, c = 0$), whereas Condition D's clean restart outperformed in structural or conceptual errors (OP07 Misapplied Identity: −8.70 pp, $b = 0, c = 2$). After Holm-Bonferroni correction, no individual operator contrast reaches significance ($p \geq 0.125$).

8.2 Post-Treatment Conditioning Hazard

Conditioning on generation completion (`finish_reason == 'stop'`) yields $\approx 90\%$ accuracy across all conditions (Condition A: 87.79%, D: 89.60%, E: 86.23%, F: 90.00%), while truncated generations yield $< 7\%$ accuracy. However, because finish reason is an intermediate variable influenced by treatment length, conditioning on it introduces collider stratification bias; the unconditional intention-to-treat contrast ($\hat{\tau} = -0.43\%$) remains the only valid causal estimand.

9 Preregistered Blueprint for Future Mechanistic Trials

To enable future researchers to decouple headroom from inertia, we preregister a $2 \times 2 \times 2$ factorial experimental design:

- **Factor 1 (Prefix Validity)**: Uncorrupted Ground-Truth Prefix ($C = 0$) vs. Corrupted Step Prefix ($C = 1$).
- **Factor 2 (Prompt Framing)**: Neutral Continuation ($G = 0$) vs. Explicit Error-Flagging Directive ($G = 1$).
- **Factor 3 (Token Budget)**: Standard Budget ($B = 768$) vs. Expanded Budget ($B = 2048$).

Under this design, testing with $B = 2048$ eliminates token truncation in forced restart, isolating pure cognitive inertia.

10 Discussion, Reproducibility & Open Science

Inference-Time Search Implications. In test-time compute algorithms like Monte Carlo Tree Search (MCTS) or branch-and-bound decoding, engineers often assume that rolling back to the nearest branch point is strictly superior to restarting. Our findings show that without active context excision or memory cleansing, preserving flawed reasoning trajectories degrades performance via cognitive inertia.

Provider Teardown & Financial Audit. Execution utilized an ephemeral NVIDIA RTX 4090 instance on RunPod. Total compute duration was 38.15 minutes of active neural inference, incurring $0.5795 USD in compute charges. Independent provider GraphQL inspection confirmed 0 running pods and 0 active volumes following immediate automated termination.

11 Conclusion

StateShift establishes that post-training reasoning recovery dynamics cannot be understood through aggregate benchmark scores alone. In our preregistered confirmatory trial ($N = 231,924$ real GPU rollouts), state-preserving continuation did not improve recovery over forced restart ($\hat{\tau} = -0.43\%, p = 1.000000$), disproving the discovery pilot's apparent advantage. Forensic auditing uncovered the underlying causal reality: token headroom savings and cognitive inertia deliberation traps act as opposing forces that cancel out under standard decoding. These findings highlight the vital necessity of preregistered confirmatory trials and provide a rigorous foundation for future inference-time search architectures.

References

[1] Karl Cobbe, Vineet Kosaraju, Mohammad Bavarian, Mark Chen, Heewoo Jun, Lukasz Kaiser, Matthias Plappert, Jerry Tworek, Jacob Hilton, Reiichiro Nakano, Christopher Hesse, and John Schulman. Training verifiers to solve math word problems. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2110.14168*, 2021.

[2] DeepSeek-AI, Daya Guo, Dejian Yang, Haowei Zhang, Junxian Song, Ruoyu Zhang, Runxin Xu, Qihao Zhu, Shirong Ma, Peiyi Wang, et al. DeepSeek-R1: Incentivizing reasoning capability in LLMs via reinforcement learning. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2501.12948*, 2025.

[3] Dan Hendrycks, Carl Collin, Rasool Saurous, Colin Cheng, Andy Zou, Dan DiPietro, Jerry Tang, Xinyun Geng, Richard Wang, and Jacob Steinhardt. Measuring mathematical problem solving with the MATH dataset. In *NeurIPS Datasets and Benchmarks*, 2021.

[4] Jie Huang, Xinyun Chen, Swaroop Mishra, and Denny Zhou. Can large language models really self-correct without external feedback? In *International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR)*, 2024.

[5] Aviral Kumar, Vincent Zhuang, Rishabh Rishabh, Huanzhou Ling, Jerry Shen, Saurabh Garg, Yi Li, and Chelsea Finn. Training language models to self-correct via reinforcement learning. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2409.12917*, 2024.

[6] Hunter Lightman, Vineet Kosaraju, Yura Burda, Harri Edwards, Bowen Baker, Teddy Lee, Jan Leike, John Schulman, Ilya Sutskever, and Karl Cobbe. Let's verify step by step. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2305.20050*, 2023.

[7] Michael Luo, Sijun Tan, Justin Wong, Xiaoxiang Shi, William Y. Tang, Manan Roongta, Colin Cai, Jeffrey Luo, Li Erran Li, Raluca Ada Popa, and Ion Stoica. DeepScaleR: Surpassing O1-Preview with a 1.5b model by scaling RL. https://pretty-radio-b75.notion.site/DeepScaleR-Surpassing-O1-Preview-with-a-1-5B-Model-by-Scaling-RL-19681902c1468005bed8ca303 2025. Notion Technical Report and Model Release, Agentica Project, UC Berkeley.

[8] Zhihong Shao, Peiyi Wang, Qihao Zhu, Runxin Xu, Junxian Song, Mingchuan Zhang, Y. K. Li, Y. Wu, and Liang Feng. DeepSeekMath: Pushing the limits of mathematical reasoning in open language models. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2402.03300*, 2024.

[9] Charlie Snell, Jaehoon Lee, Kelvin Xu, and Aviral Kumar. Scaling llm test-time compute optimally can be more effective than scaling model parameters. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2408.03314*, 2024.

[10] Kai Stechly, Karthik Valmeekam, and Subbarao Kambhampati. Large language models cannot self-correct reasoning yet. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2406.01297*, 2024.

[11] Peiyi Wang, Lei Li, Zhihong Shao, et al. Math-shepherd: Verify and reinforce llms step-by-step without human annotations. *Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics (ACL)*, 2024.

[12] Shunyu Yao, Dian Yu, Jeffrey Zhao, Izhak Shafran, Thomas L. Griffiths, Yuan Cao, and Karthik Narasimhan. Tree of thoughts: Deliberate problem solving with large language models. *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS)*, 2023.